Bukhari Chancery Persian Textbook Development

non-witnessed

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Grammatical Explanation

Turkic languages distinguish grammatically between events the speaker saw with their own eyes, and events that were reported by someone else who is usually unspecified. Central Asian Persian, shaped by centuries of close contact with Turkic languages, makes the same distinction. Whereas languages such as English would accomplish this with an additional clause ('I heard that' or 'they say that'), Central Asian Turki and Persian achieve the same effect more succinctly with dedicated verbal modes. It makes no difference whether the speaker heard the information, read it in a report, or simply inferred it: the same form is used, marking the information as not firsthand. Linguists call this category 'evidentiality': the grammatical marking of how the speaker came to know what they are reporting.

Not surprisingly, the non-witnessed mode is especially common in surviving official documents because the person writing the document (a scribe working in the central chancery) is generally not writing from firsthand experience. Central Asian Turki marks a present state as non-witnessed with ekan (ئىكەن), which serves as the verb 'to be'. For instance: siz vafodor ekansiz: '(I have heard that) you are loyal'. The particle ekan / ئىكەن can also be paired with the perfect verbal adjective -gan (غان / گەن) to indicate hearsay about past action.

For instance: bu kishi og'rini urgan ekan: '(I heard that) this man hit the thief (but I did not see the event myself)'. The -gan ekan construction is similar in meaning to the 'subjective past tense', formed with the suffix -ib and the personal endings (third person -ibdi). For instance: poezd kelibdi: '(I heard that) the train arrived'.

Central Asian Persian incorporates this logic by combining the past participle of the main verb and the present perfect of the auxiliary verb 'to be'. For instance: او را دیده‌بوده‌است: '(I) heard that (s)he had seen him/her'. A 'durative' construction (ماضی نقلی استمراری) has a similar meaning: می‌کرده‌است, '(s)he is (apparently) doing'. It describes a continuous action that often takes place in the present, though whether the action is past, present, or future depends on the sentence context. This makes it uncommon in historical texts, which generally describe completed actions in the past.

Examples

> bukh: که **فوتیده بوده است** یکنفر هندی رام سین نام در سرای بحجره صوفی هندی اکه اش اینغلام دعاگوی شنیده آدم فرموده تفتیش نمودم

> uzb: Rom Sinx nomli bir nafar hind kishi o'zining Sufiyi Hindiy (laqabli) akasining hujrasida **vafot etgan ekan** . Shu holatni bu xizmatkoringiz eshitib, odam yo'llab taftish qildik.

> fars: یک هندی به نام رام سین در کاروانسرا در حجره برادرش که صوفی هندی نام داشت و به کسی دستور تفتیش دادم **شنیده** و بنده **درگذشت**

> eng: Upon hearing that an Indian by the name of Ram Singh **had apparently died** in the apartment of his older brother, by the name of Sufi, I ordered someone to investigate.

Comments:

> The context here makes it logically clear that the author did not witness the event: he says that he heard of the death (as indicated by shunīda, 'having heard') and then sent someone to investigate. Note the contrast within the sentence: the death is reported in the non-witnessed form, whereas the writer's own action (taftīsh namūdam, 'I investigated') is in the simple past.

> Modern Iranian Persian and English have no equivalent verb form in common use, so a speaker of either makes the reported nature of the information explicit in other ways. In the Iranian Persian rendering the verb is a plain past (درگذشت) and only شنیده shows that the death was reported; the English adds 'upon hearing that' and 'apparently'.

bukh: که آقسقال … از حادثهٔ مذکوره **معلوم کرده بوده است** مسماة مذکور بایلچی خانه **اظهار نموده بود** واقف بوده شاهد میباشد … روزی مسماة مذکوره بنزد دعاگوی ذاتعالی آمده … که

uzb: Mazkur ayol elchixonaga **ma'lum qilgan ekan** ki, oqsoqol … mazkur hodisadan voqif bo'lib, guvohdir … Bir kuni mazkur ayol janobi oliylarining duogo'yi huzuriga kelib, **izhor qilgan edi** ki …

fars: که ریش‌سفید … از حادثهٔ یادشده آگاه **اطلاع داده بود** زن نامبرده ظاهراً به نمایندگی … که **اظهار کرده بود** بوده و شاهد است … روزی زن نامبرده نزد بنده آمده

- *LS: Iranian Persian needs checking by Leila;* نمایندگی *for* ایلچی خانه *and* ریش‌سفید *for* آقسقال *are provisional. The first verb is a plain pluperfect with* ظاهراً*, since the* بوده است *form is uncommon in Iranian Persian*

eng: The aforementioned woman **had (reportedly) informed** the Political Agency that the aqsaqal … was aware of the aforementioned incident and is a witness … One day the aforementioned woman came to me (His Majesty's servant) and **had stated** that …

Comments:

> The writer, a qazi, reports two statements by the same woman in two different forms. What she told the Residency he knows only at second hand, and so he uses the non-witnessed form (maʿlūm karda būda ast). What she told him in person is in the ordinary pluperfect (iẓhār namūda būd). The two forms differ only in the auxiliary: būd versus būda ast.

> Uzbek makes the same distinction with -gan ekan versus -gan edi.

bukh: چند خانه وار از کولاب کشت کار **میکرده اند** که حاکم کولاب استیفا کرده **میگرفته است**

uzb: Ko'lobdan bir necha xonadon dehqonchilik **qilar ekanlar** , Ko'lob hokimi (soliqni) undirib **olar ekan**

fars: کشاورزی [در آنجا] چند خانوار از کولاب **می‌کرده‌اند** و حاکم کولاب [مالیات را] **می‌گرفته است**

eng: Several households from Kulab **(reportedly) used to farm** [there], and the hakim of Kulab **would collect** [the tax from them].

Comments:

Both verbs are in the durative non-witnessed form, one plural (mīkarda and) and one singular (mīgirifta ast). Here the form describes habitual action in the past ('used to farm', 'would collect'), which the writer knows only from the reports of others.

The Uzbek counterpart is the aorist followed by ekan.

bukh: چنین **آگاهی نموده بوده اند** که

uzb: shunday **xabar bergan ekanlarki**

fars: چنین **آمده است** که

> eng: (I was told that) **it was made known** that...

Comments:

> This is an extremely common way for information to be conveyed in official documents: the scribing author neither specifies which individuals conveyed the information, nor does he claim to have heard it with his own ears.

> In the modern Iranian Persian example the passive construction for 'it is said' (آمده است) approximates this non-witnessed meaning; گفته شده would convey the same meaning.

> bukh: چندین دیگر مثل این نامبرده گان و از اینها پست تر مردمان امثال بزاز و چینی فروش و غیر آن را بولایت نور آتا **فرستاده شده بوده اند**

> uzb: Bu nomi zikr etilganlar kabi yana bir nechasi hamda ulardan pastroq bazzoz, chinnifurush va shunga o'xshash odamlar Nurota viloyatiga **yuborilibdi**

> fars: گفتند که چند تن دیگر مانند همین نام‌بردگان و مردمانی فروتر از اینها، از قبیل بزاز و چینی‌فروش و جز آن، به ولایت نورآتا **فرستاده شدند**

> eng: Several others like the aforementioned, and people of lower standing than these, such as cloth-sellers, china-sellers and the like, **were (reportedly) sent** to the province of Nur-Ata.

Comments:

> Nothing in this sentence says how the author knows what he reports. The verb form alone marks the exile of these men as something he learned of and did not see for himself. The source is a memoir, not a chancery document.

> The modern Iranian Persian rendering adds an explicit 'they said that' (گفتند که) to convey the same sense.

Historical-Grammatical Exploration

Unlike some of the other features of Central Asian Persian discussed in this book, the non-witnessed mode is not categorically absent in either classical or modern Iranian Persian: it is described in some grammar manuals and sometimes appears in modern media (though usually without the final است in کرده‌بوده‌است. However, this mode is more rarely used, and generally requires

additional context to clarify the non-witnessed character of the action (e.g., appearing in narration).

In some classical texts, this form may or may not clearly indicate non-witnessed mode. For instance, this example from Bayhaqi's history indicates some degree of uncertainty or conjecture: خواجه احمد] دانسته‌بوده‌است که خداوند رأیِ شکار کرده است] ("[Khwaja Ahmad] surmised that his lord intended to go hunting."

However, in most other cases, the construction as used in classical Persian texts indicates that an action took place in the distant, uncertain past. (In other words, the same construction of the past participle of the main verb and the present perfect of būdan often carries a different meaning than it does in Central Asian Persian and modern Tajik.) For instance: عرب ...طاووس ندیده‌بوده‌اند ("The Arabs had never, ever seen a peacock.") Or a more recent example: جدش پنجاه سال عمر کرده‌بوده‌است ("His ancestor, [who lived sometime in the distant, indeterminate past], had lived to the age of fifty years." 20)

By contrast, the non-witnessed mode is ubiquitous in Central Asian Persian documents, in modern Tajik (both spoken and formal), and — importantly — does not require any additional context (e.g., 'I heard that...') to clarify that the action was non-witnessed.

References

- Uyghur: De Jong (pp. 108-110, ch. XIV) treats the -ipti construction as "subjective past tense," which is "used when the present relevance of an event or act in the past has to be stressed. It implies that the speaker's words are based on hearsay, and/or that the speaker has become aware of something unexpected."
- Central Asian Persian: Perry (pp. 227-234 offers the most complete discussion of this mode, and suggests the terminology "non-witnessed mode" we have adopted.
- Iranian Persian: Ḥasan Aḥmadī Gīvī (p. 459) describes this form as the 'remote past' (māżī-yi abʿad) the speaker usually conveys the occurrence of action through a quotation and wants to highlight that they were absent and unaware of the event at the time of its occurrence but

learned about it afterwards. Gīvī further clarifies that the concepts of witnessed and non-witnessed or awareness and unawareness are weak and understated in classical Persian texts.